

HUM44-2

GMAT Preparation

Test-taking strategy, timed practice, and admission positioning

Professional infrastructure for top-tier MSc applications, not content education.

Albert School — 12 hours

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1 GMAT structure and scoring

The GMAT has four sections: Quantitative, Verbal, Integrated Reasoning, and Analytical Writing Assessment. Each is described in its own chapter below.

1.1 Scoring mechanics

The Quantitative and Verbal sections are combined into a Total Score. Integrated Reasoning and the Analytical Writing Assessment are scored separately on their own scales. The test is section-adaptive: question difficulty adjusts to the test-taker's running performance.

1.2 What top MSc programmes expect

Top-tier international MSc programmes (HEC, ESSEC, LSE, Bocconi, ESADE) either require or favour a GMAT score. Competitive applicants present scores at the upper end of each programme's published range.

1.3 Setting a realistic target score

Sit a timed diagnostic to establish a baseline. From the baseline and the published score ranges of target programmes, set a realistic personalised target score.

2 Quantitative section strategy

The Quantitative section contains two question types:

- **Problem-solving:** standard multiple-choice questions asking for a value.
- **Data Sufficiency:** questions asking whether the information given is sufficient to answer, not what the answer is.

2.1 The Data Sufficiency logic shift

For Data Sufficiency, the question to ask is “is the answer determinable?” rather than “what is the answer?”. Evaluate each statement for sufficiency, alone and combined, without computing the final value.

2.2 Time management and traps

Allocate time evenly across questions and avoid over-investing in any single item. Watch for common traps that exploit hurried reading or unjustified assumptions. Use the mathematical fluency already acquired in S1–S3 to solve efficiently rather than relearning the underlying mathematics.

3 Verbal section strategy

The Verbal section contains three question types:

- **Reading comprehension:** questions on a supplied passage.
- **Critical reasoning:** questions on the logic of a short argument.
- **Sentence correction:** selecting the best-formed version of a sentence.

The aim is to identify the reasoning patterns the test rewards, not to study English grammar from scratch.

4 Integrated Reasoning strategy

Integrated Reasoning uses four formats:

- **Multi-source reasoning:** drawing on several texts or tables.
- **Graphics interpretation:** reading graphs and charts.
- **Table analysis:** sorting and evaluating tabular data.
- **Two-part analysis:** answering two linked components.

Practise the format under time constraint. The underlying mathematics is not the focus. This competence transfers directly to professional data-interpretation tasks.

5 Analytical Writing Assessment

The AWA is a single argument-critique essay written within a 30-minute limit.

5.1 Essay structure

Structure the essay as a clear, concise critique of the argument’s reasoning.

5.2 Logical fallacies

Identify the logical fallacies the GMAT tests — flaws in the argument’s assumptions, evidence, and inferences.

5.3 Planning under time pressure

Plan the essay efficiently before writing so the full critique fits within the 30-minute constraint.

6 Timed practice

Each student completes at least two timed full sections. Each timed section is followed by score analysis and personalised feedback on weakness areas.

7 Weakness diagnosis and study planning

Each student receives a diagnostic assessment and a personalised study plan for continued preparation beyond the 12-hour course. The plan identifies weakness areas, targeted resources, and a timeline aligned with S6 MSc application deadlines.

8 Admission strategy beyond the GMAT

8.1 School selection

Select target programmes among top-tier MSc options.

8.2 How programmes weigh the dossier

Each programme weighs the GMAT score against the academic record, experience, recommendations, and essays differently. Understand each target programme's weighting.

8.3 Positioning the Albert School background

Position the Albert School background — BDD, multi-campus, data-business formation — within the full dossier (score, academic record, essays, recommendations).

8.4 Timeline alignment

Align the application timeline with S5–S6 and the S6 MSc application deadlines.